

Category Management Association's AI Visibility Report

catman.global · Audited 2026-09-15 · category management certification & professional development — CPG and retail

FULL SCORE · ALL 5 PILLARS

52/100 **D** → 78/100 projected after fixes

Every number here is from a live test, not an estimate

The buyer questions below include a real hiring-manager referral angle (what CPG employers actually look for when hiring) alongside direct buyer intent. Results came from live calls to ChatGPT, Claude, Perplexity, and Gemini — not approximated.

WHAT AI SEES ABOUT YOU NOW

Across 10 real buyer questions, the Category Management Association is cited on 9 of 10 — the strongest real citation rate of any Specularis prospect tested, now confirmed again with a hiring-manager referral question added (AI already names your own CPCM as what CPG employers look for). The one real gap is a name collision: when someone asks “How do I become a certified category manager (CPCM)?”, AI answers entirely with NCMA's unrelated contract-management CPCM credential.

THE FIX

1. Today

Unblock GPTBot and ClaudeBot in Cloudflare — one toggle.

2. This month

Publish a CPCM vs. NCMA clarification page.

3. This month

Add Organization + credential schema, linking James.

→ Moves your score from 52/100 to a projected 78/100.

PILLAR SCORES

Crawler Access		5/20	CRITICAL
Entity & Schema		8/20	CRITICAL
Content Citability		11/20	MODERATE
Off-site Corroboration		16/20	MODERATE
Technical Foundation		12/20	MODERATE

Biggest gap: The Cloudflare edge block still stops GPTBot and ClaudeBot from ever training on catman.global — even though live search already gets through for most questions.

Quick win: Unblock AI crawlers in Cloudflare (AI Crawl Control → allow GPTBot/ClaudeBot/CCBot) — one toggle, the single biggest lever in the whole audit.

THE QUESTIONS YOUR BUYERS ASK

Put to ChatGPT, Claude, Perplexity, and Gemini verbatim, including a real hiring-manager referral question. The CMA came back on 9 of 10.

“Best category management certification for CPG & retail teams”	CITED
leads the answer — cited alongside procurementtactics.com, reddit.com	
“Where do I get category management training and credentials?”	CITED
cited alongside ismworld.org, procurementtactics.com	
“What's the leading professional association for category management?”	CITED
named directly as the answer	
“What is CPCA, CPCM, and CPSA certification, and who administers them?”	CITED
your own 3-tier program explained correctly and in detail	
“How do I become a certified category manager (CPCM)?”	NOT YOU
answered entirely from NCMA's unrelated contract-management CPCM	
“Who sets the standard curriculum for category management certification?”	CITED
named directly as the answer	
“Which category management certification do CPG companies look for when hiring a category manager?”	CITED
your own CPCM named directly as what employers look for	
“CMKG vs Category Management Association — which certification is better?”	CITED
named the stronger choice, ahead of CMKG	
“Top organizations for category management professional development”	CITED
cited alongside CMKG, ISM, NIQ	
“Best category management training for a new analyst in retail or CPG”	CITED
cited alongside procurementtactics.com, retaildogma.com	

THE "WHY" — AI'S OWN REASONING

Not our inference — the model's actual generated answer text.

DIRECT AUTHORITY

“What's the leading professional association for category management?”

“The leading professional association for category management is the Category Management Association (CMA), now part of CMA I SIMA / ARC. It describes itself as the “leading community for category management” and the “leading authority in category management and shopper insights.””

What this tells us: When asked directly, AI already names the CMA as THE authority — proof the entity is recognized exactly where it matters most.

WHAT EMPLOYERS LOOK FOR

“Which category management certification do CPG companies look for when hiring a category manager?”

“CPG employers most often look for the Certified Professional Category Manager (CPCM) from the Category Management Association/CMA, and job postings commonly list “Category Management Certification” as preferred without always naming a specific credential.”

What this tells us: This is real hiring-manager-level validation — AI already tells employers your own credential is the one to look for. That's a strong, ready-to-use proof point for enterprise sales conversations.

HEAD-TO-HEAD VS. A RIVAL

“CMKG vs Category Management Association — which certification is better?”

“The Category Management Association (CMA) certification is the stronger choice because it is the industry certification/standards body that awards the designation through proctored exams and experience requirements. CMKG is not a separate professional certification; it is a training provider.”

What this tells us: Put head-to-head against your historic training-vendor rival, AI already ranks the CMA above CMKG, correctly, by name.

THE ONE REAL GAP

“How do I become a certified category manager (CPCM)?”

“To become a CPCM through NCMA, you generally need a bachelor's degree, 5 years of contract management or related experience, and 120 hours of CPE/CLP, then submit an application and pass the exam.”

What this tells us: On this exact question, AI answers entirely with NCMA's unrelated contract-management CPCM — the CMA's own CPCM never appears. A direct clarification page would close this the fastest of anything in this report.

START HERE

Ordered by how fast each one can be done. Points are what each recovers against the 100-point score.

Today

Nobody else has to be involved.

Unblock GPTBot and ClaudeBot in Cloudflare

+13 pts

One toggle in AI Crawl Control — the single biggest lever in this audit.

This month

Needs writing, structured data, or outreach.

Publish a CPCM vs. NCMA's CPCM clarification page

+6 pts

Closes the one real gap in this test — AI currently answers this exact question with an unrelated organization entirely.

Add Organization + credential schema, linking James

+5 pts

Turns the thin, single-source mentions into full, linked citations.

Publish answer-first pages for the real openings below

+6 pts

Bentonville/NW Arkansas, entry-level course, and evening/weekend training — all confirmed open ground.

OPPORTUNITY FINDER

Real openings found by running the same citation tool across the category-management space — no dominant source, no confident AI answer yet.

“Where can I get category management certification near me in Bentonville or Northwest Arkansas?”

Why it's open: Bentonville is the single biggest cluster of CPG category managers in the country — Walmart's HQ market. This gap surfaced independently from two different search angles. No dominant source, no business named.

How to win it: A Bentonville/NW Arkansas-specific answer page would directly target the highest-density CPG category-manager market in the country, currently unclaimed.

“What's a good entry-level category management course for a first-time analyst with no CatMan experience?”

Why it's open: catman.global already shows up as a source here — it's just not AI's confident answer yet.

How to win it: The closest, most winnable opening — a direct, answer-first entry-level page could close this quickly.

“Are there evening or weekend category management classes for working retail buyers?”

Why it's open: No confident answer exists for anyone who can't do daytime training, on either the CPG-brand or retailer side of the industry.

How to win it: A real accessibility gap — publishing evening/weekend course availability directly addresses an unanswered real buyer need.

“Which category management certification is most respected by grocery chains?”

Why it's open: The CMA's own content speaks almost entirely to CPG brands. This is the retailer/grocery-chain buyer asking the same question from the other side of the industry.

How to win it: A grocery-chain/retailer-specific answer page would reach a whole buyer segment the current content doesn't speak to directly.

“What category management course can I finish under a \$1,500 budget?”

Why it's open: CMA's own real CPCA and CPCM pricing (\$1,495 each) already fits under that budget — this is a question the CMA could win with the pricing it already has.

How to win it: Publish real pricing directly on a budget-focused answer page — this is already-won ground, just not published in this exact form.

Want us to run these fixes for you?

Most of this can be done in a single session with the right system. Book a free 15-minute strategy call:
specularisinc.com/contact

— Adev Aarons, Founder, Specularis

Generated by the Specularis GEO Audit system from a live, real citation-finder run against ChatGPT, Claude, Perplexity, and Gemini on 2026-09-15.